

Session 15: The Brothers Return to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- The phrase “see my face” (Gen. 43:3, 5) links Yoseph and his brothers to the reconciliation of Yaaqov and Esau, which points to the larger reality of reconciliation with God.
- Yehudah offers his own life as a substitute for the beloved son. This is what rescues the family from death and opens up the chance for life.
- Genesis 43 is Yaaqov’s Mount Moriah moment as he finally surrenders his beloved son.

Yaaqov Sends His Sons Again, With Binyamin

Yaaqov and Yehudah Go Head to Head

This unit consists of alternating dialogues between Yaaqov and his sons, but the narrative especially highlights Yehudah, who becomes the successful intercessor on behalf of the entire family.

The thematic focus points are the need to “return” to get food so that they can live and the necessity of giving up the “son/brother” to make the journey to Egypt.

This scene shows Yehudah’s transformation of character since chapters 37-38. Just as Yehudah compelled the brothers to sell Yoseph to the traders who took him to Egypt, so now Yehudah compels his father to send Binyamin so they can go down trade in Egypt. That similarity also highlights a contrast.

- In Genesis 37, Yehudah profited at the expense of the beloved son.
- In Genesis 38, Yehudah spared his only remaining son Shelah, though he gave a down payment (ערב) to gain sexual pleasure with Tamar.
- In Genesis 43, Yehudah asks Yaaqov to risk the loss of his beloved and only remaining son of Rachel by giving his own life as a down payment (ערב).

Notice the contrast between Reuven and Yehudah’s intercession with Yaaqov.

Reuven’s Offer: Genesis 42:37

And Reuven said:
“You may put to death my two sons
if **I don’t return him to you**,

Yehudah’s Offer: Genesis 43:8-9

And Yehudah said to Israel his father:
“Send the boy with me ...
I give myself as a pledge,

Comparing Reuben’s and Judah’s Offers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reuven's Offer: Genesis 42:37

give him into my hand
and **I will return him to you** .”

Yehudah's Offer: Genesis 43:8-9

from my hand you can require it,
if **I do not return him to you**
and set him before you,
then **it will be my sin** against you all the days.”

Comparing Reuben's and Judah's Offers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reuven's offer to his father shows he is ready to offer something of extreme value—the lives of his two sons. However, the idea backfires. Yaaqov would lose not only Binyamin, but also two of his grandsons (not to mention that the son making this offer is the one who betrayed him by sleeping with his wife in [35:20-22](#)).

Yehudah's offer, by contrast, shows a deep change of character, with an allusion back to [Genesis 38:17-18](#). Yehudah offers his own life as a “down-payment” (ערב), reminding the reader of his self-oriented down-payment for quick sex in [chapter 38](#). In this story, Yehudah's pledge shows a focus on the well-being of others, his father, and the life of Binyamin, as well as the lives of the children of the entire family (“our little ones”).

These narrative plot elements make a powerful point that links back to the overall themes of Genesis.

Yehudah's offer of his own life as a substitute for the beloved son is what rescues the family from death and opens up the chance for life.

Yaaqov sends the brothers and the beloved son to offer “as an offering, a little balm (צרי) and a little honey, aromatic gum (נבאת) and myrrh (לט), pistachio nuts and almonds” ([Gen. 43:11](#)). These are precisely the objects that the Yishmaelites were carrying when they took Yoseph down to Egypt ([Gen. 37:25](#)).

Yoseph Tests His Brothers a Second Time

¹⁵ And the men took this **offering**,
and they took **the double silver** in their hand,
and Binyamin,
and they got up and **they went down** to Egypt,
and they stood before Yoseph.

¹⁶ And Yoseph saw with them Binyamin,
and he said to **the one over his house**,
“**Bring the men into the house**,
and slaughter a slaughter-animal and **prepare it**,
because the men will **eat with me at noon**.”

17 And the man did just as Yoseph said,
and **the man brought the men into the house** of Yoseph,

18 and the men became afraid, because **they were brought into the house** of Yoseph,
and they said,

“It’s on account of **the silver that was returned in our sacks** in the beginning,
we are being brought in so he can roll over on us and fall upon us,
and to take us as servants, and our donkeys!”

19 And they drew near to **the man who was over the house** of Yoseph,
and they spoke to him at the door of the house,

20 and they said,

“Please, my master!

We came down in the beginning **to buy grain**,

21 and it came about when we went to the night-stop,

and we opened **our sacks**,

and look, **the silver** of each was in the mouth of **his sack**,

our silver by its weight,

so we return it in our hands,

22 and other **silver** **we have brought down** in our hand **to buy grain**.

We don’t know who put our **silver in our sacks**!”

23 And he said,

“Peace to y’all, don’t be afraid.

Elohim, and the Elohim of your fathers **has given you a treasure in your sacks**.

Your silver came to me.”

And he brought out Shim’on to them.

24 And **the man brought the men into the house** of Yoseph,
and he gave them water,
and they washed their feet,
and he gave fodder to their donkeys.

25 And **they prepared** the **offering** until Yoseph came **at noon**,
because they heard that **they would eat bread** there.

Genesis 43:15-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Brothers Prepare Their Offering

Notice how this section begins and ends with references to the “offering” (מנחה) that the brothers have prepared for Yoseph (Gen. 43:15, 25). This is the same word first used to describe the offerings of Cain and

Abel

([Gen. 4:3-4](#)), and it also alludes to the sacrifice of Noah (“offering” has the letters of Noah's name in the middle) that turned the curse of the flood into a blessing of new creation.

After this section, however, all mention of the food offering falls away because Yehudah's offering of his own life takes center stage. It's as if Yehudah becomes the real “offering” in place of the food offering.

God at Work in Hidden Ways

The brothers' fear is highlighted in [Genesis 43:18](#). They are convinced that Yoseph is setting them up for a trap because of the mistaken silver. How ironic, because Yoseph is in fact testing them with this silver, but not in the way they assume.

This scene highlights the brothers' developing characters yet again, by focusing on the silver in their bags. They know that they are innocent regarding the money, and ironically so does Yoseph, but they assume Yoseph will use it as evidence of their dishonesty. The conversation at the “door of the house” becomes the pivot point, as their fears and honesty are expressed to Yoseph's servant, who ironically tells them that “God has given you treasure!”

The irony, of course, is that while they are innocent regarding this particular silver, they are guilty of taking the silver for selling their brother in [chapter 37](#), which this silver recalls. But in this case, the brothers show that they value honesty and their brother's safety over the money, a big contrast from chapter 37.

Reflection Question

How does the phrase “you cannot see my face” in [Genesis 43:5](#) connect to the theme of the reconciliation of the brothers, and how does it play into reconciliation with God?